

New design principles for social platforms

We ended up in casinos.

Not by choice, but by design – platforms built to extract attention, maximise engagement, and serve private profit above all else.

The alternative isn't utopian; it already exists in our cities. Parks. Public squares. Gardens. Spaces that are open and transparent, full of life and difference, shaped by the people who use them and built to last.

That's what European social platforms can be.

1

Do what you say, say what you do.

Platforms should be transparent about how they work – how content is curated, amplified, and moderated – and then actually do what they claim. No hidden incentives, no gap between stated values and structural behaviour.

2

Design intentional participation

Design for deliberate, conscious participation rather than passive consumption and unconscious drift. Every feature should support users in making active choices rather than engineering behaviour they never chose.

3

Cultivate richness over reach.

Resist the growth metrics that flatten and homogenise. Healthy platforms cultivate diverse voices, perspectives, and communities – depth and variety are the measure of success, not scale.

4

Build a legacy of kindness.

Every design decision is a moral one. Build as if the people on the receiving end are people you know and care about – because they are – and ask whether what you're creating is something worth leaving behind.

Rebuild.